DODGY TRAILS

Travel agents use three routes to get illegal migrants into the US



1. AHMEDABAD-DELHI-TORONTO-US

This route has become more popular as reaching Canada on a valid visa seems more comfortable than the Turkey route. Canada is also a popular student destination now, so you can enrol in a college there first and later sneak into the US.

Time taken: 6 months

2. AHMEDABAD-DELHI-TURKEY-MEXICO-US

The most popular route. Illegal immigrants do not face any trouble for they reach Mexico on a valid visa. The porous Mexico-US border makes the unauthorised entry into the US a simple step

Time taken: 2-3 months

3. AHMEDABAD-MUMBAI-UGANDA-KENYA-MEXICO-US

Uganda and Kenya have a large population of Gujarati origin people. The illegal migrants work there for some time on a valid visa, then move to Mexico on a travel visa

Time taken: 1-2 years

MODUS OPERANDI

Most Gujaratis settled in the US recruit labour from their native place. They allegedly also facilitate the illegal smuggling



SPONSOR

A prospective US employer. Sponsor contacts relatives in Gujarat and offers them a job in the US. Often also takes care of expenses in smuggling the person into the US. Money is repaid once he/she starts earning.

FILE

Key word in north Gujarat referring to documentation needed for a US visa. A Patel community leader says youths waste years waiting for a visa. Some finally take the illegal route.

AGENT

The Gujarat police suspects a wide network of agents in Ahmedabad and north Gujarat who lure the youths. Agents are connected to middlemen in Mexico, Canada and the US.

STUDY CENTRES

Hoardings in Gandhinagar are full of ads on how to study in the US and Canada. The counsellors reportedly guide many clients on the 'illegal route'.

RELIGIOUS CENTRES

Many Gujaratis have illegally stayed back in the US to work in local temples. Their travel visa expired a long time back but a nexus with local authorities helps.

Source: Gujarat Police, community leaders

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

On January 19, it was this American connect that fetched Dingucha international attention. Four residents of the village—Jagdish Patel, wife Vaishali, daughter Vihangi and son Dharmik—were found frozen to death over 11,000 km away in Manitoba on the Canada-US border. They had reportedly planned to walk into the US with 11 other Gujaratis, without valid documents. They wore heavy winter coats, masks and gloves to protect them from temperatures which fell 35 degrees below freezing, but were tragically separated from the larger group. The family "faced not only the cold weather but endless fields, large snowdrifts and complete darkness", Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP) assistant commissioner Jane MacLatchy told the media on January 22. Their bodies were found just a kilometre away from the US border. The family had set out from Gujarat to Canada on valid tourist visas in late December.

The day after the tragedy, US authorities arrested van driver Steve Shand, who was driving two undocumented Indian passengers. US immigration authorities found and detained another group of five Indian nationals in the vicinity who also reportedly crossed over from Canada. All of them now face legal action in the US.

PATEL PIPELINE

The US has been a hot destination for Gujarati migrants, both legal and illegal, for decades. US census data from 2014 showed that Gujaratis, who are just 6 per cent of India's population, comprise 20 per cent of the people of Indian origin (PIOs) in the US. They have over the years gone on to run successful businesses, mostly motel chains and grocery stores. Around 40 per cent of the hospitality business in the US is run by Guja-